FOCUS ON TRANSPORT & FLEET · 9 NOVEMBER 2026

Transport emissions are 9% above 1990. NI has the fewest public chargers in the UK.

Moving people and goods on an island economy: what fleet operators, hauliers and employers can do while the infrastructure catches up.

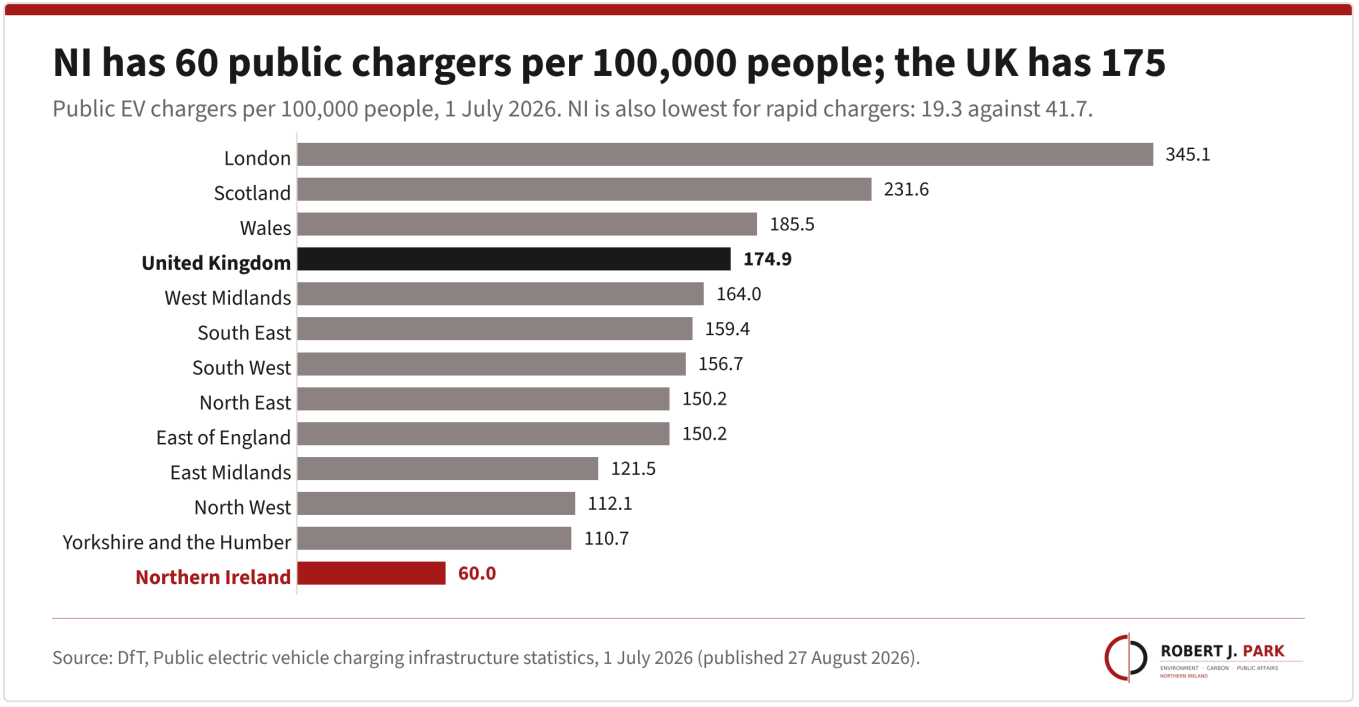
By Robert J. Park · robertjpark.co.uk · WhatsApp @robertjpark

21.3%
of NI emissions come from domestic transport, the second-largest sector

+9%
rise in transport emissions since 1990

60
public EV chargers per 100,000 people in NI, against 175 across the UK

84.0m
Translink passenger journeys in 2025-26, above the pre-COVID level



Public EV chargers per 100,000 people, 1 July 2026. Source: DfT, Public electric vehicle charging infrastructure statistics, 1 July 2026.

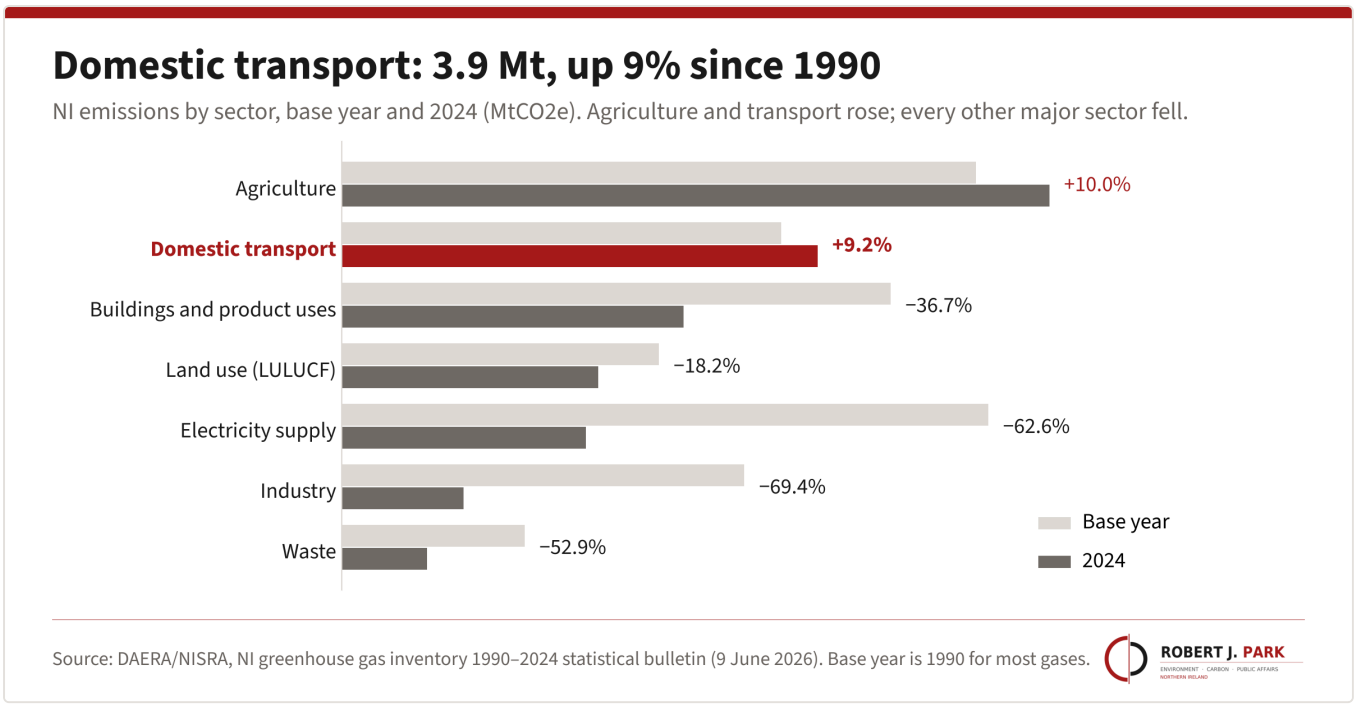
Domestic transport produced 3.9 million tonnes of CO2e in Northern Ireland in 2024: 21% of the total and 9% more than in 1990. With agriculture and fuel supply, it is one of only three sectors whose emissions have risen since 1990, and road vehicles are the main reason. NI has the lowest density of public chargers in the UK, interest in buying an electric car has fallen again, and public transport has only just passed its pre-COVID level. For businesses, fleet and freight are where action pays fastest.

WHERE EMISSIONS SIT

Road traffic drives the total

Cars, vans and lorries are the main source of NI transport emissions and the main reason for the rise since 1990, although emissions are still a little below their pre-COVID level. The inventory also counts leaks from vehicle air conditioning and refrigerated transport here. When a vehicle goes

electric its emissions move to the electricity grid, and half of NI's electricity now comes from renewables, so each switch gets cleaner as the grid does.



NI emissions by sector, base year and 2024 (MtCO2e). Source: DAERA/NISRA GHG inventory 1990–2024.

CHARGING

Lowest in the UK on both measures

At 1 July 2026, NI had 60 public EV chargers per 100,000 people, against 174.9 across the UK and 231.6 in Scotland. For rapid chargers (50 kW and above), NI had 19.3 per 100,000 against a UK average of 41.7.

The gap shows in attitudes. In NISRA's 2024/25 survey, only 19% of drivers said they would definitely or strongly consider an EV as their next car, down from 25% a year earlier and 38% in 2021/22. Purchase price (75%), the need to recharge (54%) and the availability of public chargers (44%) were the biggest barriers.

For fleets, depot and workplace charging matter more than the public network. Cars and vans that return to base each night are the easiest to switch.

COSTS

What has changed for business vehicles

- **Electric Car Grant.** The UK Government's grant is open in NI, to private buyers and fleets: up to £3,750 off eligible new zero emission cars priced up to £37,000. Funding was raised to £1.3bn in the 2025 Budget and runs to 2030.
- **Company car tax.** Benefit-in-kind on zero emission company cars is low but rising: 4% in 2026/27, 5% in 2027/28, 7% in 2028/29 and 9% in 2029/30. Plug-in hybrids rise faster, to 18% and then 19%.
- **Car sales rules.** The GB zero emission vehicle mandate, which sets EV sales targets for manufacturers, is made under an Order covering Great Britain only. NI's position depends on separate legislation.

- **Heavier goods.** Since 1 August 2026, NI drivers who have held a car (category B) licence for two years can drive zero emission goods vehicles up to 4,250 kg, or up to 5,000 kg where the extra weight is specialist equipment for disabled users.

FREIGHT AND THE IRISH SEA

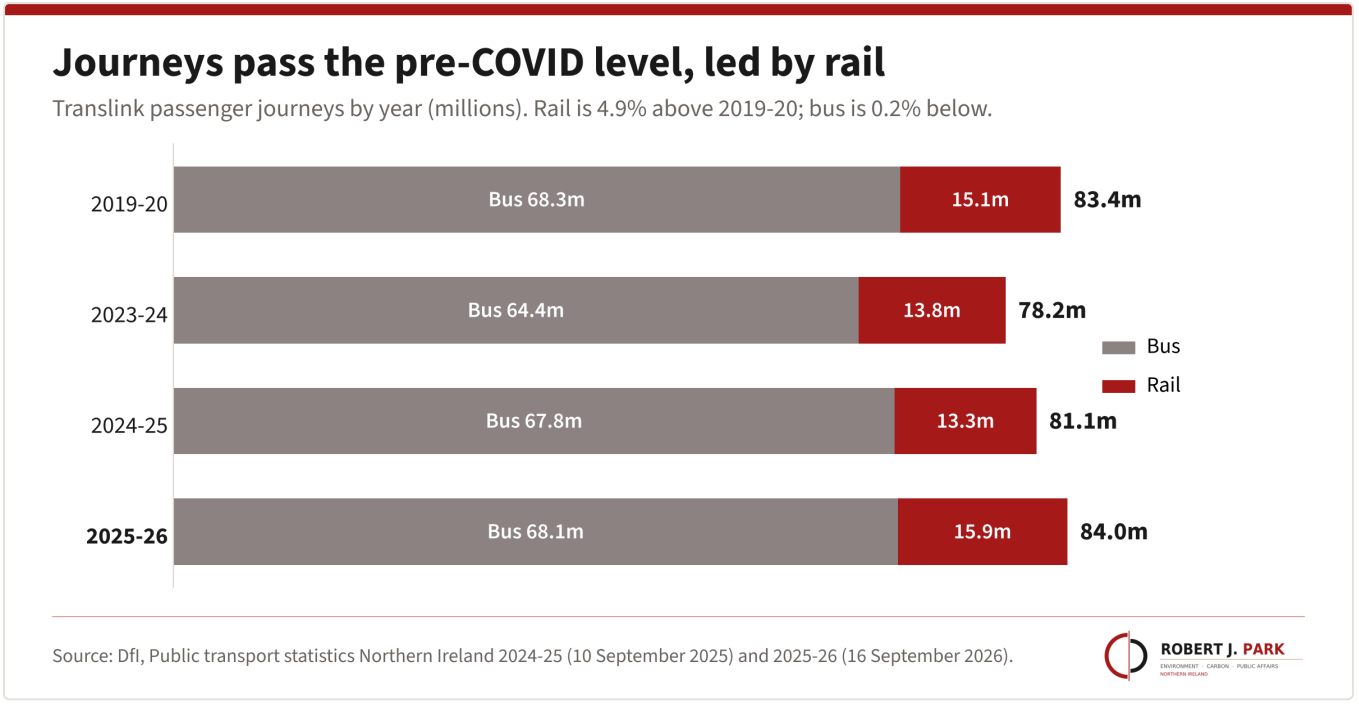
Ferries now carry a carbon price

Since 1 July 2026, the UK Emissions Trading Scheme has covered cargo and passenger ships of 5,000 gross tonnes and above on domestic voyages. Sailings between Great Britain and Northern Ireland are included, with a 50% deduction on the allowances operators must surrender, and port stays in NI count in full. Expect the cost to show up in freight and ferry rates, and ask carriers for emissions data: it is part of your Scope 3.

PUBLIC TRANSPORT

Rail has recovered, buses nearly

Translink carried 84.0 million passengers in 2025-26, up 3.6% on the year and above the 83.4 million of 2019-20. Rail journeys (15.9 million) are now 4.9% above their pre-COVID level; bus journeys (68.1 million) are 0.2% below. For employers, travel plans, cycle-to-work and public transport schemes, and flexible start times are cheap ways to cut commuting emissions, which are part of Scope 3.



Translink passenger journeys, millions. Source: DfI, Public transport statistics NI 2024-25 and 2025-26.

POLICY AND DEADLINES

Six dates to watch

WHEN	WHAT	WHO IT AFFECTS
Since 1 Jul 2026	UK ETS covers domestic shipping, including GB–NI sailings	Ferry operators; freight and ferry customers
6 Apr 2027	Zero emission company car BIK rises to 5%	Company car drivers and employers
5 Dec 2027	ESOS phase 4 notification deadline (includes transport energy)	Large businesses
31 Dec 2027	End of NI's first carbon budget	All sectors
6 Apr 2028	Zero emission company car BIK rises to 7%	Company car drivers and employers
30 Apr 2028	First UK ETS surrender for shipping, covering 2026 and 2027 emissions	Ferry operators

THIS MONTH

Three things a fleet operator can do

1. List every vehicle with its annual mileage, fuel use and typical daily route. Vehicles that do under 150 miles a day and return to base are your first EV candidates.
2. Get a quote for depot or workplace charging, and check your site's grid connection capacity before you order vehicles.
3. Record grey-fleet mileage (staff using their own cars for work). It is often larger than expected and belongs in your Scope 3.

See the numbers behind this briefing

The NI Transport and Fleet dashboard sets out every figure used here: public and rapid chargers for every UK nation and region, transport emissions, Translink journeys, driver attitudes to EVs and company car tax rates. Each chart can be downloaded as a CSV.

Open the dashboard

Where does each journey count?

The Scopes Map explains where company vehicles, commuting, business travel and freight sit in Scopes 1, 2 and 3, including grey areas such as leased and grey-fleet vehicles.

Open the Scopes Map

Reading these figures with care

- **Inventory.** Emissions are counted where fuel is burned. EV charging is counted under electricity supply.
- **Chargers.** DfT replaced "charging devices" with an "EV chargers" measure from January 2026, so older figures are not directly comparable. The 1 July 2026 figures are the latest quarterly release at 9 November 2026; the next, for 1 October, is due on 25 November.
- **Attitudes survey.** Covers 2024/25 and only respondents with a driving licence.
- **Company car rates** apply to UK tax years starting 6 April.

SOURCES

Where the figures come from

- NI greenhouse gas inventory 1990–2024 statistical bulletin (DAERA/NISRA, 9 June 2026)
- NI GHG inventory user notes: sector definitions (NISRA)
- Public EV charging infrastructure statistics, 1 July 2026 (DfT, 27 August 2026)
- Attitudes towards electric vehicles in NI 2024/25 (DfI/NISRA, 4 December 2025)
- Attitudes towards electric vehicles in NI 2023/24 (DfI/NISRA)
- Public transport statistics NI 2025-26 (DfI, 16 September 2026)
- Public transport statistics NI 2024-25 (DfI, 10 September 2025)
- Electric Car Grant open in NI (DfI, 25 July 2025)
- Electric Car Grant launched: grant bands and £37,000 price cap (DfT, GOV.UK, 15 July 2025)
- Electric Car Grant: £1.3bn more, extended to 2030 (DfT, GOV.UK, 3 December 2025)
- Company car tax: appropriate percentages for 2028 to 2030 (HMRC, GOV.UK)
- The Vehicle Emissions Trading Schemes Order 2023
- Category B weight limit raised for zero emission goods vehicles (DfI, 30 July 2026)
- UK ETS scope expansion: domestic maritime, main Authority response (UK ETS Authority, GOV.UK, November 2025)
- UK ETS expands to maritime from 1 July 2026 (DNV)
- Electricity consumption and renewable generation, year ending June 2026 (DfE)

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NORTHERN IRELAND

Focus on Transport & Fleet is a monthly briefing by Robert J. Park, an independent environment, carbon and public-affairs consultant based in Larne, Northern Ireland. Robert helps businesses and councils measure fleet and travel emissions, plan the switch to zero emission vehicles and build Scope 3 inventories.

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